

Moral Ambition: What Is Success? [B2]

In una società dove avere successo significa fare carriera e guadagnare stipendi da capogiro, c'è chi sceglie di dare più valore ai propri principi.

Strive not to be of success, but to be of value," Albert Einstein once said. In today's world, modern capitalism has supercharged a basic human instinct for survival into an all-consuming pursuit of status and wealth. So for many high-achieving university students who are about to hit the job market, success is narrowly defined by prestigious titles and high salaries. The School for Moral Ambition seeks to challenge this definition and replace it with a more meaningful one, training future leaders to measure their success by the positive impact they have on the world. In late 2025, the School, already present in Europe, launched its Moral Ambition Fellowship for Harvard University undergraduates, marking a significant expansion into the US.

RUTGER BREGMAN

The School for Moral Ambition was the brainchild of Dutch historian Rutger Bregman, author of upbeat best-sellers such as Utopia for Realists and Humankind: A Hopeful History. Bregman's concern with the widening gap between awareness and action informed his 2023 book Moral Ambition, in which he questioned whether books and debates alone were enough to create real change. The Moral Ambition Bus, a travelling initiative by historian Rutger Bregman and The School for Moral Ambition, targets top talent on US college campuses, encouraging students to dedicate their careers to solving urgent global problems. Inspired by historical movements such as the British abolitionists, who combined idealism with entrepreneurial ambition, Bregman envisioned an organisation that would redirect talented graduates away from purely profit-driven careers and toward solving global challenges, such as climate change, economic inequalities or corporate practices that harm long-term human wellbeing. The idea was to merge

the [mindset](#) of activists with the execution power of startup founders.
Culture

Repair Cafés: Make Do And Mend In questa società usa e getta, la vera rivoluzione sta nel riparare e rammendare. Abitudini che fanno bene all'ambiente... e al portafoglio! Daniel Francis , Julian Earwaker

A PATH TO IMPACT

To bring this vision to life, Bregman [teamed up](#) with professionals, building the School as both a global movement and a practical platform, offering fellowships or creating Moral Ambition Circles that help people translate values into action. European fellows have gone on to found organisations, publish influential research, speak in national parliaments and help shape public policy. With offices in New York City, Amsterdam, and Brussels, the School for Moral Ambition initially focused on European talent before turning its attention to American universities. Harvard was chosen as the fellowship's launch site because elite institutions often [channel](#) large numbers of exceptional students into finance or technology. According to a recent [survey](#) of Harvard [seniors](#), more than half planned to enter these sectors after graduation. For students facing [mounting tuition](#) costs and debt, lucrative corporate jobs can be difficult to refuse — even when personal values point [elsewhere](#).

MORAL AMBITION FRAMEWORK

Don't start with what you're passionate about, start with what needs to be done. That means focusing on challenges that are: How big is the problem? How many people or animals would benefit if it were solved? Good intentions aren't enough. Look for convincing evidence that progress is possible: that the problem can actually be solved. The world often focuses on the most visible problems. Look for those that others ignore, where your efforts can have the greatest impact.

Glossary

- **awareness** = consapevolezza
- **tuition** = tasse universitarie
- **Sizable** = grande
- **high-achieving** = di grande successo
- **undergraduates** = studenti universitari
- **upbeat** = ottimista
- **profit-driven** = orientate al profitto
- **mindset** = mentalità
- **teamed up** = fare squadra
- **channel** = indirizzare
- **survey** = sondaggio
- **all-consuming** = totalizzante
- **job market** = mercato del lavoro
- **mounting** = crescente
- **elsewhere** = altrove
- **Strive** = sforzarsi
- **of value** = di valore
- **supercharged** = sovralimentare
- **Fellowship** = borsa di studio
- **informed** = influenzare
- **merge** = fondere
- **seniors** = studenti dell'ultimo anno
- **Overlooked** = ignorare
- **brainchild** = idea
- **widening gap** = divario crescente